

9) Your shortcut set

Microsoft's shortcut list for multiple desktops is the official baseline.

Core

- Win + Tab → Task View
- Win + Ctrl + D → New desktop
- Win + Ctrl + Left/Right → Switch desktops
- Win + Ctrl + F4 → Close current desktop

Touchpad

- Four-finger swipe left/right → switch desktops

60-second practice drill

Do this once, and you'll remember forever:

1. Press Win + Ctrl + D twice (now you have 3 desktops).
2. Press Win + Ctrl + Right twice, then Left twice.
3. Press Win + Tab, drag one window between desktops.
4. Close the current desktop with Win + Ctrl + F4.

Congratulations. You now *own* this feature.

10) Three copy-paste workflows

Workflow A: Student (Study / Class / Personal)

Desktop 1: Study

- PDF reader + Notes app + Browser (research)
- Folder shortcut: Downloads (because PDFs will live there)

Desktop 2: Class

- Google Meet/Zoom + Slides + Attendance portal
- Keep this desktop clean so you never screen-share something embarrassing

Desktop 3: Personal

- WhatsApp Web + YouTube/Spotify + shopping/social

Why it works: You can switch contexts instantly without closing anything. And your "Class" desktop becomes a "presentation safe zone".

Workflow B: Office / WFH (Work / Meetings / Admin)

Desktop 1: Work

- Email + Excel + browser tabs for work portals + shared docs

Desktop 2: Meetings

- Teams/Zoom + calendar + meeting notes
- This desktop exists to prevent the classic disaster: presenting the wrong window.

COMMON MISTAKES (AND HOW TO AVOID THEM)

Mistake 1: Creating 9 desktops and naming none

- If you can't describe your desktops in one sentence, you've built a maze.
- Fix: Keep it to 3–5 desktops. Rename them.

Mistake 2: Leaving taskbar set to "all desktops" and calling desktops "cluttered"

- Windows literally lets you choose taskbar behavior across desktops. Use it.

Mistake 3: Using virtual desktops but still Alt+Tabbing like a maniac

- Use Win + Ctrl + Left/Right for desktop switching.
- Use Alt+Tab *within* a desktop, not *across your entire life*.

Mistake 4: Ignoring touchpad gestures on a laptop

- Four-finger desktop switching is built-in on precision touchpads. If it doesn't work, your laptop may not have a precision touchpad, or gestures may be mapped differently.

Desktop 3: Admin

- HR portal, timesheets, VPN tools, ticketing, file transfers
- Pro move:** Configure taskbar to show windows only on the desktop you're using so your meeting desktop stays uncluttered.

Workflow C: Developer (Code / Run / Reference / Personal)

Desktop 1: Code

- VS Code/IDE + Terminal + file explorer

Desktop 2: Run/Test

- Browser + app preview + logs + Postman (or equivalent)

Desktop 3: Reference

- Docs, GitHub, PDF specs, course videos

Desktop 4: Personal

- Keep it separate. Your brain will thank you.

Why it works: Coding is context-heavy. Separating "write" from "run" reduces cognitive load and keeps your IDE from being buried under browsers. 📌